



Report Date: April 17, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

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TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Director, Business Services
SUBJECT: 2026 City of Vancouver Public Fireworks Celebration – Special Event

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Park Board approve an application from the City of Vancouver to host the 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration at English Bay Beach Park with all arrangements to the satisfaction of the General Manager of the Park Board.
- B. THAT the Park Board approve an application from the City of Vancouver for a Special Event Permit from the BC Liquor & Cannabis Regulation Branch to serve alcohol at the aforementioned location with a maximum capacity of 100 guests.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

The 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration is a new, one-night fireworks event proposed by the City of Vancouver to take place at English Bay Beach Park in Summer 2026. The event date is still under consideration and will be announced once finalized. The event will be free and fully accessible to residents and visitors and is expected to utilize a footprint and delivery model similar to the popular and long-standing Celebration of Light Fireworks Festival that was cancelled indefinitely in November 2025.

The purpose of this report is to present the 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration to the Board, seek Board approval for this application, and authorize the General Manager of the Park Board to approve the detailed event terms/conditions.

BOARD AUTHORITY AND PREVIOUS DECISIONS

Per the [Vancouver Charter](#), the Park Board has exclusive jurisdiction and control over all areas designated as permanent and temporary parks in the City of Vancouver, including any structures, programs and activities, fees, and improvements that occur within those parks.

As informed by the [Guidelines for Special Events](#), the [Special Events Policy \(2003\)](#), as well as current practices, the Park Board reviews and approves new major special events, as well as significant changes or revisions to existing major special events.

On October 19, 2020, the Park Board approved the [VanPlay Framework](#), for Vancouver's [Parks and Recreation Services Master Plan](#). VanPlay sets out priorities and provides tools and policies to support the pursuit of equity, connectivity, and access to parks and recreation for all. The Framework provides a succinct method for referencing and implementing VanPlay directions. The 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration supports and aligns with VanPlay's directions to "Welcome Everyone", "Weave the City Together" and "Deliver Services Equitably".

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Celebration of Light Fireworks Festival

In November 2025, the Vancouver Fireworks Festival Society announced the indefinite cancellation of the Celebration of Light fireworks event after rising production and operating costs, loss of federal funding, reduced provincial support, and declining private sponsorship, made the multi-night event financially unsustainable.

Following the cancellation announcement, the Mayor of Vancouver publicly expressed disappointment over reductions in senior-government funding and affirmed the City's willingness to explore ways to ensure Vancouverites can continue to enjoy a major summer fireworks celebration.

City Council Motion

Following the indefinite cancellation of the Celebration of Light fireworks event, Vancouver City Council passed a motion on February 4, 2026, directing staff to plan and deliver a one-night City-enabled public fireworks event to be held in Summer 2026. City Council also approved the allocation of up to \$2,000,000 from City reserves, contingency funds, and/or other available sources to support the delivery of the one-night fireworks event.

Following City Council's February motion, staff have initiated preparations for a one-night public fireworks event and undertaken initial coordination with public safety agencies and key delivery partners to confirm event requirements, footprint, and viable date options. This work is progressing, however, given the already compressed summer event calendar, peak seasonal demand on citywide resources, and additional pressures associated with hosting FIFA World Cup 2026, staff are carefully assessing potential event date and operational feasibility.

2026 Public Fireworks Celebration

The 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration is a one-night fireworks display in English Bay that will be fully open and accessible to residents and visitors free of charge. While detailed event planning stills needs to be completed, it is anticipated that this initiative will be delivered in a similar manner to the longstanding Celebration of Light event, albeit with less complexity.

Event Location

The proposed event site, English Bay Beach Park, was selected in consultation with the FEST Committee due to its scenic backdrop, ease of public access, and many years of well-established precedents from previous Celebration of Light fireworks events.

DISCUSSION

Event Proposal

As enablers of the 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration, the City of Vancouver is seeking approval to deliver a free and accessible one-night fireworks event at English Bay Beach Park in Summer 2026 (date to be determined). While more detailed event planning is still required, this initiative is expected to follow a delivery model similar to that of the longstanding Celebration of Light event, albeit with less features. While the initiative is expected to include a modest lounge space with alcohol service on the bathhouse rooftop and a small selection of food trucks, the event will not include a drone show, the Inukshuk Lounge hosting space, large grandstand seating, or activations in Morton Park and adjacent spaces.

Since the City of Vancouver does not directly produce events and given the already compressed timelines alongside a demanding summer schedule, production and operational planning for the 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration will be outsourced to a qualified team with demonstrated experience in delivering large-scale public events and navigating City processes. Staff are currently working with the City's Supply Chain Management Department to finalize the scope of work and contract deliverables, and as of April 13, have issued a Notice of Intent to Contract (NOITC) signaling the City's intent to engage the BrandLive Group as their production partner. BrandLIVE is a Vancouver-based event production company with extensive local experience delivering major public events, including over a decade as their primary delivery partner for the Celebration of Light fireworks event and working with key event stakeholders. This approach is expected to enable the efficient use of existing operational plans and leveraging of relationships required as a result of the shortened planning window.

Consistent with its mandate, the Vancouver Park Board will continue to act as facilitator and regulatory body rather than event producer. Park Board staff will be responsible for permitting, oversight, and ensuring public safety requirements are met, while the detailed logistical planning, execution, and event funding will be managed by the City of Vancouver and BrandLive.

This event will be supported by the FEST Committee as well as the FWC26 Host Committee, subject to Board approval and development of the requisite operational plans.

Event Set-Up/Tear-Down

Set-up for the 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration is expected to require up to 2 days; tear down is anticipated to be completed within 2 days of event delivery.

Event Benefits

The 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration is expected to play an important role in building community connections and civic pride and provide an opportunity for Vancouverites and visitors to enjoy a shared cultural experience without financial barriers.

Staff recognize that sensitivities and concerns exist when access to public spaces is restricted, and as a result, consider all requests of this nature very carefully. Staff are supportive of pursuing this initiative due to its marquis nature and the meaningful benefits that would accrue to the public, the Park Board, and community stakeholders. These include:

- Large scale engagement of residents and visitors through a popular event concept;
- Building and strengthening of community connections and civic pride through shared participation in a cultural experience without financial barriers;
- Collaboration and support for local suppliers and partners;
- Promotion of Vancouver as a destination for tourism, support for long-term economic activity, and enhancement of the City's reputation; and
- Filling of a noticeable gap in Vancouver's summer events calendar, created by the recent cancellation of the long-standing Celebration of Light event, during the peak tourism season when the City will be welcoming an elevated numbers of visitors and international visibility.

KEY CONSIDERATIONS

Financial Impacts

All expenses related to the delivery and execution of this event will be borne by the event organizer; accordingly, there will be no costs to the Park Board related to this initiative.

Beach and Park Access

The event organizer will develop a plan to minimize disruptions to public access to English Bay Beach Park and maintain/share access as long as it is safe and operationally possible to do so.

Unlike the multi-day Celebration of Light fireworks event, which included large grandstand seating areas, the Inukshuk Lounge, a drone show and activations at Morton Park and adjacent areas, the required set-up/tear-down time for the 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration will be much shorter (4 days) resulting in significantly less impact to public beach and park space access.

Neighbourhood Notification and Communication

The organizer of the event will be required to prepare and deliver a communication strategy/plan, including timely delivery of neighbourhood notification to surrounding residents and businesses in consultation with the FEST Committee.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

With the cancellation of the longstanding Celebration of Light fireworks event, the City of Vancouver's 2026 Public Fireworks Celebration presents an exciting opportunity to deliver a popular fireworks event to Vancouver residents and visitors. Through its delivery, this free and fully accessible event will showcase the City's premier waterfront spaces and contribute to the City's cultural, tourism, and economic vibrancy during a period of elevated visitation and international visibility.

Park Board staff have carefully considered the various aspects of this application and are confident that this initiative can be executed successfully and as intended. Accordingly, staff recommend that the Board approve this application as outlined above.

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APPENDIX A

Preliminary Site Concept/Layout



Figure 1: Site Plan at English Bay Beach on Shore



Figure 2: Site Plan at English Bay Beach on Water